A List of Compositions by Loren Rush

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Five Kokinshiu Poems

for soprano, flute, clarinet, viola and harp (1959), 6 min.

Nicola di Lorenzo Prize 1959, University of California, Berkeley
Formerly titled *Five Japanese Poems*

Premiere: Anna Carol Dudley, Composers' Forum ensemble, KPFA-FM broadcast, Berkeley, March 6, 1959
Lenoir Hosack, Composers' Forum, San Francisco, May 1959
Valarie Lamoree, Philadelphia Composers' Forum, Philadelphia, October 1967
Wendy Haight, Stanford University ensemble, Stanford, Nov 1968
Claudia Cummings, San Francisco Contemporary Music Players, San Francisco, March 1976

Last season's all-outness proved that it has reached classic status in *Five Japanese Poems*, set by Loren Rush in a haunting, aphoristic, Webern-like tissue. Rush's work exemplified to perfection a sensitive unity of word and tone.

— Alfred Frankenstein, SF Chronicle, May 26, 1960 —

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Serenade

for Violin and Viola (1960), 15 min.

I. Intrada II. Aria 1° III. Scherzo IV. Aria 2° V. Finale

new edition (1997)

Nicola di Lorenzo Prize 1960, University of California, Berkeley.

Gail Denny and William Denny (movements 2,3,4), Berkeley, May 11, 1960
Premiere: Robert Bloch and Mary James, San Francisco, July 1960
Kent Rose and Asbjorne Finess, Composers' Forum, San Francisco, March 1962 and KPFA-FM broadcast, Berkeley, May 1962

The *Serenade* was completed on the last day of 1959 in Point Richmond, a bayside village several miles north of Berkeley. At the time of composition I was studying privately with Robert Erickson and with Charles Cushing, William Denny, Andrew Imbrie and Seymour Shifrin as a graduate student at the University of California. It was awarded the 1960 Nicola di Lorenzo Prize by the Berkeley composition faculty.

Movements two, three and four were premiered on May 11, 1960 at the newly built Hertz Hall on the Berkeley campus by William Denny (viola) and his daughter Gail (violin), then an undergraduate at Berkeley. The full premiere was given by Robert Bloch and Mary James in San Francisco in July of the same year. A subsequent performance was given by Kent Rose and Asbjorne Finess at a San Francisco Composers' Forum concert in March, 1962.

The new edition with revised notation was completed in August, 1997. It contains three concepts that were not available to me at the time of composition: the notation of rhythmic nuance, the notation of just intonation in a shifting, chromatic context, and the notation of nested phrasing elements.

— Loren Rush, program note —

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String Quartet

(1960–61), 23 min.

Prince Pierre of Monaco Musical Composition Award 1971
Publisher: Theodore Presser Company

Premiere: San Francisco Contemporary Music Players: Roy Malan (violin), Robert Galbraith (violin and viola), Nancy Ellis (viola), Robert Sayre (cello), Jean-Louis LeRoux, conductor, San Francisco, October 7, 1976

Recording: The San Francisco Contemporary Music Players, Jean-Louis LeRoux, cond., 1977. George Craig for Composers Recordings, Inc. CRI LP 381. Produced by Loren Rush and Carter Harmon

The String Quartet in C# Minor is dedicated to my friend and teacher Robert Erickson. It was begun in Point Richmond, a village across the bay from San Francisco, in the winter of 1959-60, my final year as a graduate student at the University of California at Berkeley and completed in Bois Colombes, a village near Paris in the spring of 1961, my first year as recipient of the University of California's Prix de Paris fellowship. In 1971, while I was in Rome as a recipient of the Rome Prize it received the Prince Pierre of Monaco Award from a jury chaired by Nadia Boulanger.

The quartet was written for an imaginary ensemble of virtuoso string players. That is, the virtuosi did exist and I had heard them play, but they weren't playing in the same quartet. It is in one movement which is the result of five individually characterized sections. In the large central section the second violinist changes to viola with the lowest string tuned down a minor third. The quartet is expressed in a highly chromatic environment in which the chromaticism is structured throughout by tonal reference.

Fifteen years were to pass from its completion until artists of the extreme levels of virtuosity and sensitivity necessary to perform this work were to find it and each other. The String Quartet was premiered on October 7, 1976 by Roy Malan, Robert Galbraith, Nancy Ellis and Robert Sayre, members of the San Francisco Contemporary Music Players, with Jean-Louis LeRoux conducting at the San Francisco Museum of Modern Art. Two weeks later, at the First Unitarian Church of Berkeley, these artists were joined by the admirable recording engineer George Craig to make this recording, which was completed in one session.

—Loren Rush, recording notes, 1977—

In Rush's quartet, solemnity alternated with what sounded like wild catch-as-catch-can cacophony. With all the sore tooth edge in these dissonances, they did their part in building up good musical interest.

— Alexander Fried, San Francisco Examiner, Oct. 8, 1976 —

It was a fierce activity of motives so fractionated as to be hardly definable. What Rush did with this atomized material was also quick, excitable, compressed and contrasting to the blinding point, except for some clear events, like spacings of dramatic silence, and the final return to the slow opening progressions.

—R. Commonday, San Francisco Chronicle, Oct. 9, 1976 —

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Mandala Music

improvisation schema for three or more performers (1962), variable duration

Premiere: Performer's Choice 1, directed by Rush, concert and KPFA-FM broadcast, Berkeley, February 25, 1963
Festival of Contemporary Arts, University of Illinois, March 1963
Hartt Chamber Players, I.S.C.M., New Haven, May 1963 and Conn. Fine Arts Foundation, Hartford, December 1963
Once, Ann Arbor and Eastern Michigan Univ., December 1963
Fromm Players, directed by Rush, Festival of Contemporary American Music, Berkshire Music Center, August 1964
New Hampshire Music Festival, Center Harbor, August 1964
Society for the Performance of Contemporary Music, directed by Rush, San Francisco, December 1965 and Stanford, January 1966
Alea II, directed by Rush, Stanford University New Music Ensemble, November 1969

Mr. Rush's *Mandala Music* used five players. The audience got the giggles when Mr. Zukofsky punctuated a violin phrase with a boom from a base drum, which he played by means of a pedal. After that any loud sound sent the listeners off again. The players were in earnest though. It is the kind of piece that receives a first performance every time it is played since the players agree on what order they want to play the available groups of improvisatory material each time it's played. This time around it sounded fine.

— Howard Klein, New York Times, August 14, 1964 —

The work is an exercise in discipline for both the composer and the improvising performers. The formal pattern shapes the the performance: this is not structureless music. This formal and structural imperative underlies most of Rush's music, but it is at its most obvious here, in *Hexahedron* for solo piano, and in *Nexus 16* for chamber orchestra.

— Charles Shere, Ear, Berkeley, March, 1973 —

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Piano Music 2

for two prepared pianos, bells, gongs and cymbals (1962–63)

variable duration

Darmstadt Ferienkurse, directed by Karlheinz Stockausen, Darmstadt, West Germany, July 1962
Premiere: Joan Goodwin and Dwight Peltzer, Performer's Choice 4, concert and KPFA-FM broadcast, San Francisco, Oct. 30, 1963
Natalie Hinderas and Dwight Peltzer, Academy of Music, Phil., March 1968

Hexahedron

for piano (1962–63), variable duration

Premiere: Dwight Peltzer, Berkeley, November 15, 1964
Recordeding: Dwight Peltzer, 1977. Serenus LP, produced by Loren Rush
Other performances:
Loren Rush, American Academy in Rome, November 1969

Rush's music, except for an occasional burst of fireworks, is notably lyrical, quiet, even impressionistic. It is the kind of music that Debussy might have written if Webern had gotten there first.

— Alfred Frankenstein, S.F. Chronicle, Nov. 17, 1964 —

Mr. Rush's *Hexahedron*, while sometimes sounding remarkably like recycled Ravel, plainly was the work of a skilled pianist and composer. Although there were superficial aspects to its toccata style, the piece pleased the ear at all times and succeeded in its limited aims.

— Donal Henahan, New York Times, February 12, 1972 —

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Nexus 16

for chamber orchestra (1964) 13 min.

Commissioned by the Fromm Music Foundation and the Berkshire Music Center
Highest award, Concours de Composition Musicale de Royaumont, 1965
Publisher: Theodore Presser Company

Premiere: Festival of Contemporary American Music, Berkshire Music Center, Fromm Players, Eduardo Mata, conductor, Aug. 12, 1964
Recording:San Francisco New Music Ensemble, Howard Hersh, conductor, 1971, Wergo LP WER 60057

Other performances:

University of Illinois Summer Workshop, Salvatore Martirano, conductor, July 1965
L'Ensemble Ars-Nova (O.R.T.F.), Marius Constant, conductor, Saison Musicale de Royaumont, Royaumont Abbey, France, concert and national radio broadcast, September 1965
Composers' Forum 20th Anniversary Concert, Loren Rush, conductor, Berkeley, Nov. 1965
L'Ensemble Ars-Nova, Diego Masson, conductor, concert and national radio broadcast, Paris, January 1967
L'Ensemble Ars-Nova, André Jouve, conductor, Royaumont Foundation Concert, Royaumont Abbey, France, May 1967
Stanford University Chamber Orchestra, Loren Rush, conductor, Stanford, May 1968
New Music Ensemble of the University of California, San Diego, Alan Johnson, conductor, February 1969
San Francisco New Music Ensemble, Ron Daniels, conductor, S.F., October 1969
Contemporary Directions, Sydney Hodkinson, conductor, Ann Arbor, October 1970
New and Newer Music, Dennis Russell Davies, conductor, New York, November 1972
Contemporary Music Ensemble, Cincinnati Conservatory, Orcenth Smith, conductor, Cincinnati, April 1974
Die Reihe Ensemble, Friedrich Cerha, conductor, Vienna, date
San Francisco Symphony ensemble, Niklaus Wyss, conductor, San Francisco, Aug. 1975
New York Philharmonic ensemble, Pierre Boulez, conductor, New York, October 1976
DePaul University, Chicago, November 1977
Musical Elements, Dan Asia, conductor, New York, February 1978
Monday Evening Concerts, William Kraft, conductor, Los Angeles, May 1978
Brooklyn Philharmonic Orchestra, Lukas Foss, conductor, New York, March, 1987

On August 12, 1964 Eduardo Mata conducted the Fromm Players in the premiere performance of Nexus 16, commissioned by the Fromm Music Foundation, at the Berkshire Music Center (Tanglewood). Nexus 16 is scored for three instrumental groups (string quartet, woodwind quartet, and brass quartet) that encircle a central group of pianist, two percussionists and double bassist. The conductor indicates the passage of time by arm movement that follows the second hand of a clock while directing nuances with the free hand, a conducting technique originated by John Cage for his influential work *Atlas Eclipticalis*.

— Loren Rush, program note —

With its players spaced in an arc across the stage, Rush's *Nexus 16* touched off a delicate, sometimes thunderous wonderment of vagrant sounds.

— Alexander Fried, San Francisco Examiner, Nov. 15, 1965 —

. . . beautiful . . .

— Bertram Levy, Perspectives of New Music, Spring 1966 —

Mr. Rush provided the best music of the evening. He obviously has a superb ear, because he had the 16 players in his piece producing a gorgeous array of delicate sonorities besides a surprising number of relatively conventional harmonies.

— Raymond Ericson, New York Times, October 31, 1976 —

The best piece on the program was Loren Rush's *Nexus 16*, a work for sixteen players dating from 1964. Rush is a Californian, now working with computer music—in which, he said at the concert, he finds 'magic.' There is some of that quality, too, in this twelve-year-old work for live players: a great deal of elegance in the handling of sounds, and a fair amount of genuine, contemporary wit. The piece works somewhat on chance; some elements are left to improvisation, and some of the confluences are accidental. This is only the second piece of Rush's I have heard in New York; Ozawa did his *Cloud Messenger* a couple of years ago. He is a remarkably gifted composer, now in his forties.

— Alan Rich, New York Magazine, November 15, 1976 —

At a Brooklyn Philharmonic 'Meet the Moderns' program I revisited Loren Rush's *Nexus 16*, its bristling complexities still fresh, still staggering after 23 years.

— Alan Rich, California Magazine, June, 1987 —

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dans le sable

for soprano, speaker, four altos and chamber orchestra (1967–68) 22 min.

orchestral version (1970)

Publisher: Theodore Presser Company

Premiere: Renée Grant-Williams, soprano, and Robert Moran, speaker, San Francisco Conservatory Artists Ensemble, Ron Daniels, conductor, 'West Coast Music 1968,' San Francisco, January 12, 1968

Other performances:

Renée Grant-Williams and Robert Moran, San Francisco Conservatory Artists Ensemble, Ron Daniels, conductor, San Francisco, February 1968

Renée Grant-Williams and Alan Gohlman, UCSD New Music Ensemble, Alan Johnson, conductor, San Diego, April 1969

Orchestral version premiere: Elvira Spica and Domenico Perna, RAI Symphony Orchestra of Rome, Ferruccio Scaglia, conductor, concert and national radio broadcast, Rome, September 26, 1970

Contemporary Directions, Sydney Hodkinson, conductor, (orchestral version), Ann Arbor, February 1972

Anna Carol Dudley and Martin Bresnick, San Francisco New Music Ensemble, Loren Rush, conductor, March 1972

Saint Paul Chamber Orchestra, Sydney Hodkinson, conductor, (orchestral version), Minneapolis, June 1972

Elisabeth and Robert Suderberg, The Contemporary Group, Stuart Dempster, conductor, University of Washington, Seattle, Jan. 1973

Eastman Chamber Orchestra, Sydney Hodkinson, conductor (orchestral version), Rochester, November 1974 and February 1975

Renée Grant-Williams and Charles Shere, La Jolla Civic/University Orchestra, Alan Johnson, conductor (orchestral version), San Diego, March 1975

Capitol University, Conservatory of Music, Columbus, Ohio, May 1975

Michigan State University Orchestra, Dennis Burkh, conductor, (orchestral version), East Lansing, November 1975

New American Music Ensemble, Stephen Robert Kleiman, conductor, La Rochelle Festival, La Rochelle, France, July 1976

Nina Hanson and Edgar Weinstock, San Francisco Conservatory New Music Ensemble, John Adams, conductor, October 78

New Music Ensemble's touching magic

Mozart was an old master composer, but in a curious way it was his genius that saved a modern-minded New Music Ensemble concert from the doldrums last night at the de Young Museum. To be exact, nobody performed any Mozart piece pure and simple. Yet Barbarina's aria from his *Marriage of Figaro* emerged within the evening's music anyway, and it did so with touching magic.

Gently distorted, fragmented and reassembled, the aria lay at the core of a work by Loren Rush called *Dans le Sable*—"In the Sand.' In *Figaro* the aria is a beautiful expression of distress as the girl Barbarina searches anxiously for something she had lost.

Similarly *Dans le Sable* seeks its mood as a quiet, faintly bewildered speaker utters the thoughts of a modern man who feels he is a lost soul.

Along with the continually altered Mozart melody, Rush's music uses a repetitious, naive but sensitive tune of his own. As the piece proceeds, orchestral sound and a few lofty choral voices spin out a tonal pattern that variously floods over the Mozart motif or sinks into the background behind it.

Hence a listener hears and feels Mozart's enchantment much in the way he might see a lovely vision under the surface of shimmering water. Through it all, Rush's score sustains a graciously varied, sure unity of poetic feeling, until at last it melts into silence.

— Alexander Fried, SF Examiner, March 11, 1972 —

On last week's concert, Loren Rush provided a score called *Dans le Sable* which amounted to a surreal opera scene. A narrator dwells on the significance of passing time. A soprano sings Barbarina's cabaletta from *Figaro*, which describes her distraught search in the sand for a lost pin. The chamber orchestra—mostly solo instruments—plays soft, half-forgotten tunes reminiscent of the Parisian music hall.

If Marcel Duchamp wanted to put painting once more at the service of the mind, so did Rush seem to want to make a composition that speaks directly to that thing behind the mind—the point where it connects with the soul.

And he succeeded. But only because the work is so brilliantly constructed, so careful in its structure and the timing of its phrases, so well balanced in the disposition of its parts that it quite overcomes the audience.

— Charles Shere, Oakland Tribune, March 19, 1972 —

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soft music, HARD MUSIC

for three amplified pianos (1969–70), 20+ min.

Premiere: Daniel Perlongo, Richard Trythall and Loren Rush with Studio R7 di Roma: American Academy in Rome, Feb 28, 1971 and USIS Library, Rome, March 1971
Recordeding: Dwight Peltzer, 1977. Serenus LP, produced by Loren Rush

Other performances:

Alea II, Stanford New Music Ensemble, directed by Rush, Stanford University and Sonoma State College, November 1972

Loren Rush's *HARD MUSIC* (1970), for three amplified pianos, treats a traditional instrument in a new way, exploiting the differences in spectrum obtainable from the harder touches. Each performer plays a fast repeated low D (just above cello C). There is no melodic figuration. Thus the surface of the music consists of fast composite rhythms formed by the ensemble of percussive attacks and the interplay of the partials. The dynamic marking is fortississimo throughout, and the sound breaks apart in such a way that some of the partials, especially the fifth through the ninth, are easily heard as individual pitches. At especially loud places in the music the clangorous higher partials take over, and the effect is somewhat like distant bells. The content of the music is sound. The individual attacks are so closely spaced that musical changes are felt more as continuous than discrete, and one follows those changes as one watches clouds forming and reforming.

— Robert Erickson, Sound Structure in Music,
University of California Press —

. . . The resulting sound is interesting, if one's attention span is up to it, but the work seems a minor piece in the output of a major composer.

— Charles Shere, Oakland Tribune, November 29, 1972 —

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Oh, Susanna

for piano (1970), 9 min.

Publisher: Theodore Presser Company

Premiere: Richard Trythall, American Academy in Rome, May 30, 1971
Recording: Dwight Peltzer, 1977. Serenus LP, produced by Loren Rush
Other performances:
Joseph Kubera, Stanford, November 1973
Dwight Peltzer, concert and WNYC radio broadcast, New York, April 1974
Donald Berman, included on U.S. 2000 concert tour and American Academy in Rome New York concert, October 16, 2002

Oh, Susanna is a set of seamless variations on the wedding march from Mozart's *The Marriage of Figaro*. It was written in Rome in 1970 and premiered there the following year by Richard Trythall. It was written as a diversion from the composition of an orchestral work *The Cloud Messenger* (1971) and as an exploration of techniques that would later be used in another orchestral work *Dreaming Susanna - fantasy on a theme by Mozart* (1973). It is a study in the careful balancing of phrases and the maintenance of tonality through highly chromatic textures, beginning somewhat abstractly and gradually uncovering more of the theme until, at the end, the theme is presented unadorned—the bride stripped bare.

Oh, Susanna is a theater piece of restrained means (theater of the mind) written for inclusion in a concert of contemporary piano music. It concerns a solo performer, the twentieth century pianist Figaro, who finds that his usual relationship with the audience—being the conjurer of new musical experiences—is somehow being subverted and internalized. He begins, appropriately enough, playing a modern work of some elegance and finesse, only to find in it images of his own past, of Susanna, his bride, and of their wedding. Their wedding march, not particularly evocative on its own, becomes increasingly internalized and sensuous due to Figaro's inability to dissociate Susanna from the music of his memory. Eventually, Figaro loses contact with his audience and withdraws into his past.

— Loren Rush, program note —

Rush's *Oh, Susanna*, Played by Peltzer, Proves Exquisite

The most striking music on Dwight Peltzer's piano recital program Thursday evening at the Washington Square Church, a part of the Composers Theater May Festival series, was by Loren Rush, a composer from the San Francisco Bay area.

The most appealing of his works was called *Oh, Susanna*. The Susanna in question is not she of the American folk song, but the character in Mozart's *Nozze di Figaro*. The piece begins in a lazy, chromatic cloud of random notes, dreamy and abstract, but very slowly bits and pieces of the wedding march from the third act of Mozart's opera emerge, more and more coherently, with the whole only stated as such at the very end, like the end of Bach's 'Goldberg' Variations. It is an exquisite piece, one that combines conceptual ingenuity, structural integrity and surreal evocativeness in a rare and refreshing manner.

— John Rockwell, New York Times, April 6, 1974 —

It's a fine, quiet, gentle piece that says a lot about Rush's continuing preoccupation with that most difficult of problems facing the contemporary artist: how to deal with the past.

—Charles Shere, Oakland Tribune, September 2, 1972 —

The work resembles a number of other compositions of Mr. Rush's: *Reverie*, *Dans le Sable*, *I'll See You In My Dreams*—all work which presents the process of music as the subject of music (and, like *Dans le Sable*, *Oh, Susanna* is dominated by a constant reference to Mozart's *Marriage of Figaro*). These works are conceptual, to use the jargon of contemporary art commentators: they are concerned with process, with concept and the execution of concept, to a much greater degree than they are concerned with sound itself. It may well be objected that this has always been the case: but that is decidedly not true with much of the contemporary avant garde. Rush is, in fact, a conservative composer, concerned with the musical tradition, aware of all the recent breakthroughs and appreciative of them, but still willing to use tonality if it suits him.

Like the earlier *Hexahedron* for solo piano (1964), *Oh, Susanna* is an eminently pianistic, effective recital piece. It lies down well with the best of the traditional piano repertoire, while moving the tradition a bit further on its way — surely the most to be asked of a new work.

— Charles Shere, Ear, Berkeley, March, 1973 —

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The Cloud Messenger

for orchestra (1966–71) 18 min.

Premiere: RAI Symphony Orchestra of Rome, Giampiero Taverna, conductor, concert & national radio broadcast, Rome, July 10, 1971
San Francisco Symphony Orchestra, Seiji Ozawa, conductor, San Francisco, April 1973
San Francisco Symphony Orchestra, Niklaus Wyss, conductor, Soviet Union Tour: Leningrad, Vilnius and Moscow, June 1973
Boston Symphony Orchestra, Seiji Ozawa, conductor, East Coast Tour: Boston, Providence, Raleigh, Hackensack and New York, October and November 1974, plus BSO radio transcription series
Boston Symphony Orchestra, Seiji Ozawa, conductor, Midwest Tour: Detroit, Ann Arbor, Bloomington Ind., Wheaton Ill. and Iowa City, April 1975

San Francisco Symphony Has a Winner

The San Francisco Symphony won't be making an empty gesture when it takes Loren Rush's *The Cloud Messenger* to Europe as an example of contemporary American music. No, sir, it will be taking along one winner of a piece, an 18-minute tone poem that really works, that keeps you absorbed, that even has soul.

Seiji Ozawa and the orchestra offered a preview of the Rush yesterday afternoon at the Opera House for those mad music lovers who would come in from the welcome sun. Not only did it turn out to be a piece with a future, but its fabric of numerous soloistic sounds was brilliantly unfolded, and I couldn't help wishing it had been recorded on the spot.

There is no specific 'Cloud Messenger' in Rush's piece, we have the composer's word for that, but you could say there are some clouds. Or, better, lots of space. There's a great deal of liquidity in the score, a pervasive transparency, and a lot of it really floats.

Rush has given personality, fascination and musicality to his 'Messenger.' The music builds, fractures and rebuilds with an unfaltering imagination, and a fine sense of shape, too. There's a hauntingly lyric, long-noted cello passage which recurs towards the end just as it had been announced earlier at a point in time about the same distance from the beginning.

Occasionally, the beautiful and spacious wash of sustained and sprinkly sounds is interrupted, Ives-like, by ruder gestures (in this case from the Pop world, complete with electric guitar) but these interruptions are well-spaced, and soon it's back to music which Ozawa conducted with great inexorable circular motion, producing in the listener great feelings of calm and good feeling.

Rush just about puts you in Nirvana, even if another station comes in now and then.

— Arthur Bloomfield, SF Examiner, April 9, 1973 —

The work is very solidly crafted. Scored for a large orchestra, with each string part individually composed, there is a great deal of surface detail in both sound and structure, but the underpinnings are just as important, and just as carefully placed. Many musical avant gardes of the last generation have taken Debussy as mentor; *The Cloud Messenger* seems to continue in Ravel's footsteps, matching surface wash to structural solidity.

The work is melodic, and tonal in its references if not its overall structure. It is sculptural in its shape, not thematically developmental: thematic groups are treated as individual units, stated, left, and restated.

Some sections need rhythmic force, and are composed metrically; others are free, and conducted in great sweeping circles. From time to time driving blues-derived sections obtrude on an otherwise luminous and speculative sound. The piece begins softly and simply continues to exist for a while—a long while, you may think, but it needs its length in order to amass its density, its weight.

Beauty has nothing to do with *The Cloud Messenger*, though it is beautiful in the conventional sonic attribute of the term. Truth has more relevance here, for the work states some nonverbal thing about our time in its sound and its structure, just as surely as any successful orchestral piece of any other time has spoken for its."

— Charles Shere, Oakland Tribune, April 9, 1973 —

Symphony Brings Modern Music to Russia

LENINGRAD — Modern music has officially had a bad name in Soviet Russia since Stalin's time. But conductor Seiji Ozawa boldly put a great deal of it into his San Francisco Symphony Leningrad programs. Surely the Ministry of Culture accepted it and the public response so far has been not at all unfriendly.

As a prime example, Ozawa's assistant, Niklaus Wyss, conducted *The Cloud Messenger* by Bay Area composer Loren Rush. It is a crowdedly complex instrumental web of tone-color texture, a sort of atmospheric 'theater of the mind.'

A crowd that overflowed the cleanly white, handsome, loftily columned Philharmonia Hall listened to it and watched such of its unusual elements as its huge sheet music on the conductor's stand and Wyss' slow, round, clockwise beat during some of its freely conceived passages.

Listeners were both soothed by its delicate suggestiveness and jolted by its dissonant explosions. At the end of its 20-odd minutes, some people didn't move a hand. Plenty of others did respond and their applause built up for several minutes. Wyss received a hand for himself. Younger standees reacted most vigorously.

— Alexander Fried, San Francisco Examiner, June 18, 1973 —

BSO performs The Cloud Messenger

At the Fromm Foundation's contemporary music festival at Tanglewood in 1964, Erich Leinsdorf heard a newly commissioned piece by a then 29-year-old composer called Loren Rush. Impressed, he asked Rush to write something for the Boston Symphony. Rush set to work, but abjuring any suggestion of 'nomen est omen,' he took his time over the project. Lots of time—and that is how it came about that *The Cloud Messenger* reached the Boston Symphony 10 years and two Music Directors later. Seiji Ozawa, who gave the American premiere in San Francisco in April 1973—the world premiere having taken place in Rome in 1971—introduced it here at last night's concert.

In a program note, Rush evokes Le Corbusier on his church at Ronchamp—". . . this difficult achievement with its infinitely demanding thorough details, strong in its means of expression, but extremely sensitive, and informed throughout by mathematics, the creator of the ineffable mystery of space." Indeed, Rush's sense of musical space is sure, and the surface of his piece is facinatingly,

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sensuously detailed. Even so, I am inclined to describe *The Cloud Messenger*, which I found most attractive, as essentially simple.

Its core is a slow music, preternaturally slow really, in familiar tonic-and-dominant harmonies, of faintly Spanish cast, whose most prominent feature is a high, wandering trombone solo (dreamily played by William Gibson). All that, which goes on for about 17 minutes, is subject to two kinds of disturbance. One is constant and takes the form of a filigree of soft chatter and twitter, which delicately encrusts the core in dissonance and textural unrest. The other consists of percussive explosions which momentarily drown out the Spanish trombone dream two or three times for perhaps half a minute each.

And that is all—a simple but telling conception, painstakingly and imaginatively worked out, and making a gorgeous sound.

— Michael Steinberg, Boston Globe, October 4, 1974 —

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A Little Traveling Music

for enhanced piano with computer-generated four-channel audio playback (1971–73), 10.5 min.

Commissioned by Dwight Peltzer

Premiere: Peltzer, concert and WNYC radio broadcast, New York, April 4, 1974
Recordedings: Dwight Peltzer, 1977. Serenus LP, produced by Loren Rush;
Dwight Peltzer, Computer Music Currents 2, Wergo CD 2022-50, 1989, produced by Loren Rush
Other performances:
Margaret Fabrizio, virginals, Stanford, March 1975
Pierre-Laurent Aimard, IRCAM, Paris, April 25, 1977

A Little Traveling Music was written for Dwight Peltzer during 1971-73 as a sketch for the second movement of *Song and Dance*, an orchestral work. Peltzer premiered *A Little Traveling Music* in New York on April 4, 1974. The computer-generated sound was created at Stanford University's Center for Computer Research in Music and Acoustics (CCRMA), of which I was a co-founding director. The real-world sounds were captured by means of a portable digital recording system.

The computer synthesis is an application of two digital techniques developed at CCRMA—the simulation of moving sound sources, where the apparent location of the sound in the simulated listening space can be specified, and a unique extension of frequency modulation (FM) synthesis where the spectral evolution of each sound is a function of its travel through virtual space.

The synthesized sounds are based on the first ten partials of the harmonic series of E2 (E above cello C). Each of the ten pitches is a complex gong-like timbre, repeatedly struck, that travels about in space independently from the others. Each of the gong-like timbres is tuned such that if the first partial of the note is pitch n of the harmonic series of the fundamental E, than the second partial is the same pitch as the (n+1)th note of the fundamental series.

The piano part is, in the lower range, a fast-repeated drone on the second partial of the fundamental series. In the upper range, the pianist plays highly articulated repeated figures that tend to blend somewhat with the synthesis. This material is alternated with sections built on a drone on A (the tonic) which conflicts with the fundamental drone of the synthesis. These alternating sections tend to break the timbral cohesiveness of the sections built on E.

The piano is tuned in a five limit system of Just Intonation designed by Loren Rush and Alfred Owens, with tuning by Alfred Owens. A feature of the system is the introduction of acoustical beats that are the result of slightly detuning the third string of each three-string pitch. The pure tuning is heard when only the upper two strings are struck (*una corda*); the 'mixed' tuning is heard when all three strings are struck.

—Loren Rush, recording notes, 1989—

Concentrating on the last two decades, Peltzer offered a variety of pieces to illustrate the struggle by the younger generation of composers to throw off the heavy cloak of Webern-style serialism.

If not every item seemed a cogent alternative to Webern, three works by Loren Rush did reveal an especially original and versatile creative force, and each proved Peltzer a sympathetic and persuasive interpreter.

. . . Far from these [referring to *Hexahedron* and *Oh, Susanna*] lay Rush's *A Little Traveling Music.* Together with the synthesized accompaniment, Peltzer's live sound in this dense, relentlessly driving music suggested a combination of gamelan and sitar—crowned by a long, dark pedal point worthy of the capstone on a grand fugue of Bach!

—Lawrence B. Johnson, Milwaukee Sentinel, Feb. 23, 1978—

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Dreaming Susanna

Fantasy on a Theme by Mozart

for electronically enhanced orchestra and six-channel audio plaback (1973) 20 min.

Commissioned by Niklaus Wyss and the San Francisco Symphony Orchestra for the 1973 Summer Music Workshop
Formerly titled *I'll See You in My Dreams*

Workshop Premiere: San Francisco Symphony Orchestra, Niklaus Wyss, conductor, San Francisco, Aug. 10, 1973

Dreams Haunted by Mozart

The San Francisco Symphony wound up its ten-day Summer Workshop Friday with the premiere of Loren Rush's *I'll See You In My Dreams*, a work commissioned for the occasion. Like other recent works of Rush's *Dreams* is haunted by Mozart's opera *The Marriage of Figaro*. In fact, it is the final (and voiceless) scene of an opera itself, a work in progress Rush calls *On The Beach*. To that end Friday morning's performance incorporated tape recorded sounds of surf breaking.

Although Mozart is quoted in the piece, the effect is not one of musical collage. As in his vocal scena *Dans le Sable* and his piano piece *Oh, Susanna*, Rush is here concerned with a restatement of Mozartian themes. His work is neither hommage nor update, but music about music.

Like many surrealists, Rush deals with a second level. Musical sensations are developed which carry psychological qualities akin to the sharp nostalgia Proust's hero associates with his famous tisane and madeleine. And these touches of recognition—they're too gentle to be called shocks—are effected not merely with pitches and timbres, the primary ingredients of musical thought, but with whole readymade phrases, which affect those of us who know Figaro as German folk tunes must have affected Beethoven's audiences.

But *Dreams* is not intellectual music. It's dreamy, easy to hear, undemanding of its audience. For the student audience Friday it was preceded by some of Rush's sketches, and by the Figaro wedding march it contains; but none of this is really necessary—the work makes its own way. It was beautifully played, its Daphnis and Chloe-like climax cresting tastefully under Niklaus Wyss' free but controlling leadership.

— Charles Shere, Oakland Tribune, August 12, 1973 —

Tender Trap of Brilliant Music

The 1973 Summer Music Workshop of the San Francisco Symphony ended with a kind of ecstatic commotion Friday in Lowell High School Auditorium. Composer Loren Rush managed to produce yet another of his ultra-poetic pieces, this one for and to the delight of the 800 Workshop students.

Commissioned for the Workshop, Rush's *I'll See You in My Dreams* was given its premiere by the San Francisco Symphony under Niklaus Wyss. Wyss did a fine job with it, following his successes conducting Rush's *Cloud Messenger* through the Soviet Union on the recent Symphony tour.

The commission poses a difficult problem for the composer. He must write a work which will somehow incorporate a full professional symphony orchestra and all the students of the workshop. A simplistic solution, such as freely notated improvisations for 900 musicians, won't work. Previous attempts proved that much. Rush, currently associated with the Electronic Computer Studio of Stanford University, has produced an original and most admirable alternative. He set a tender trap for the minds of his listeners, and caught them.

Dreams is a fantasy for full orchestra, magnetic tape and 'other effects' which is a sonic metamorphosis of Mozart's Wedding March from *The Marriage of Figaro*. Various segments of the orchestra play the march, often slightly out of phase, altered in tempo, rhythm and orchestration. At times, one particular aspect of the Mozart will be worked over and savored—the little Turkish episode in minor keys, for instance. The general idiom, replete with the sounds of surf from magnetic tapes, is advanced. Yet the whole of the piece is curiously euphonious, if anything, a little more so than the original Mozart.

In a brief lecture-demonstration before the performance, Rush said he was attracted to the Mozart March for several reasons. In form, it begins very softly offstage, and gradually builds, but to an inconclusive ending. "One is never sure the wedding will take place." Along with the air of questioning, it also was an example of Mozart deliberately writing a period piece, a work which looked backward to the style of a previous age. Rush in effect continued these natural aesthetic tendencies of the piece. It looks backward to the Eighteenth Century while strolling and dreaming through the sonic world of today.

Dreams is a fine piece on its own terms. But the application of it to the needs of the workshop was brilliant. First, all the various ensembles—bands, string orchestras and orchestras—played the original Mozart March as part of their summer repertory. Next, simplified versions of the Rush score were provided by the composer so that players of assorted proficiencies could play some of it, or at least sizable quotations. Thus the students were exposed to both Mozart's and Rush's versions of the same work through the summer.

When they came to the hall on Friday morning, they finally heard what had been building in their ears and fingers for two weeks; the complete *I'll See You in My Dreams*. Rush sat at the electronic console, controlling the entrances and volume levels of the waves. This was one factor omitted from the preparation. Another surprise was a large net of inflated, colored balloons, suspended above the center of the room: the 'other effects' mentioned in the program.

Just as the March, *Dreams* and the surf reached their climaxes, a light signal to an electric eye released the balloons in a marvelous shower over the jumping, yelling and utterly delighted kids. Rush had drawn the live sound of children's happy squealing into his climax. What a lovely way to end a 25-minute connotative study of a wedding march. One misguided school official did everything he could to suppress this hubbub. Fortunately for the piece, the composer and the audience, he failed.

—Hewell Tircuit, San Francisco Chronicle, August 11, 1973 —

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Song and Dance

for amplified orchestra with computer-generated four-channel audio playback (1975) 24 min.

I. Softly, as in a Morning Sunrise

Recording: San Francisco Symphony Orchestra, Seiji Ozawa, conductor, San Francisco, December 3-6, 1975

2. A Little Traveling Music

Recording: Detroit Symphony Orchestra, James DePriest, conductor, Detroit, February 1979

Commissioned by Seiji Ozawa and the San Francisco Symphony Orchestra

Premiere: San Francisco Symphony Orchestra, Seiji Ozawa, conductor, San Francisco, December 3-6, 1975. Broadcast on National Public Radio, November 1976
St. Louis Symphony Orchestra, Leonard Slatkin, conductor, St. Louis, December, 1977 (included in radio transcription series)
Minnesota Orchestra, Leonard Slatkin, conductor, Minneapolis, April 1978 (included in radio transcription series)
Detroit Symphony Orchestra, James DePriest, conductor, Detroit, February 1979 (included in radio transcription series)

The all American program had offered sound and light, and dance and synthesizers, plus an audacious world premiere to boot. *Song and Dance* by Loren Rush served up two equal contrasting movements obsessed with the idea of the A minor mode. The first, a post-Ives piece of hypnotic immobility, furnished sustained shimmering sonorities from the giant orchestra, without episodes. The second, on the road from Cowell's *Rhythmicana* to Riley's *In C*, locked on to tonic and dominant triads of the minor mode and loved them to death, providing the punch line with a cadential close on—surprise!—the major tonic chord. Drone-like elements out of Hindu music and untuned chime-like clanks out of a pretaped synthesizer were accoutrements of this work representing an increasingly prevalent extreme reaction against the atonality of the past generation.

— Paul Hertelendy, Oakland Tribune, December 4, 1975 —

The second movement is as rich and compelling a piece of contemporary music as has been heard in a good while. The difference is primarily that of a driving rhythmic sense which lends form to the movement and creates a dramatic tension that is delt with and finally resolved in terms of harmony rather than dissonance.

For this second part, the orchestral score is supplemented by a four-channel tape of artificial sounds synthesized from a computer. To this end, the orchestra was flanked by a sound system that would have done justice to Pink Floyd. (Indeed, the visceral, driving beat of this section makes it ripe for exploitation by some rock super-group as the intro music to yet another over-engineered album.) The range of musical textures and patterns produced by the computer tape must be heard to be believed.

Most pervasive is a persistent metallic droning at regular intervals which recalls the rich background provided by the tamboura in South Indian music. Accompanying this rhythmic 'zonging,' as of so many electronic rubber bands, is a persistent tambourine-like rhythm that suggest the matchless Golden Monkey chant of Indonesia. Then, too, there is a marvelous, metallic, percussive sound that convinces the listener he is entering Alberich's forge in Wagner's *Seigfried*.

All the while the orchestra plays a raga-like score against the tape producing a dark middle-Eastern kind of sound as varied in its acoustic array as is a Persian rug in its visual pattern of repetition.

Hopefully we can look forward to new works from Rush and his colleagues in this same vein, where the computer is exploited for its ability to synthesize sounds previously unknown to the human ear.

— Thaddeus Carhart, Stanford Spectrum, Dec. 11, 1975 —

The effect was not unlike that of a Javanese gamelan—great waves of microtonal intervals splashing together and somehow resolving in dreamy, slightly askew harmonies; tunes taking shape in the mist and vanishing; a lot of repetition (like the tambourine taps) that anchored the piece in one's attention but never went back over exactly the same ground.

— Frank Peters, St. Louis Post Dispatch, Dec. 9, 1977 —

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Preludes for the Enhanced Piano

1. Mattina (Morning) in seven limit just intonation, 5 min.
2. Dolce declina il sole (Softly, the Sun Declines) in five limit just intonation, 15 min.

Recording: Performance by Loren Rush included on the limited edition CD The Enhanced Pianos from Good Sound Foundation. Produced by Loren Rush and Janis Mattox

Giorno d'un uomo

for violin and enhanced piano in seven limit just intonation (1996). Part I of IV.

1. Mattina (Morning), 12 min.

Commissioned by Daniel Kobialka

Omaggio a Giuseppe Ungaretti

for piano (1997), 14 min.

two versions: 1) enhanced piano in five limit just intonation, 2) equal tempered piano

A pianistic expansion of *Veglia* from *L'allegria*

Premiere: Loren Rush, equal temperament version, Benefit Concert for Joe Catalano, July 13, 1997, Berkeley.
Recording: The premiere performance. A limited edition CD available from Good Sound Foundation.

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L’allegria

for baritone, violin, cello and enhanced piano (2002), 35 min.

I. Veglia (Night Watch) II. In memoria (In Memorium) III. Giugno (June)
IV. I fiume (The Rivers) V. Mattina (Morning)

Commissioned by Thomas Buckner

Workshop performance: Thomas Buckner or Milton Williams (baritone), Susan Freier (violin), Stephen Harrison (cello), Matthew Edwards or Joseph Kubera or Loren Rush (piano); (date)

L'allegria (The Joy) is being written for baritone Thomas Buckner and pianist Joseph Kubera with violinist Susan Freier and cellist Stephen Harrison. Each movement has been conceived of as inhabiting a unique acoustical environment that will be accomplished by the use of GoodSound Virtual Acoustics. The enhanced piano is tuned in 5-limit just intonation.

This composition is built on the poetry that Giuseppe Ungaretti wrote during his years in the trenches of World War I—poems that are the substance of the collection ***L'allegria***, 1914-1919. This most sensuous of Ungaretti’s poetry expresses the transcendence of beauty over brutality —the creation of beauty as a political, humanizing act.

Ungaretti was born in North Africa and spent most of his life there until the war. He maintained his sanity in the trenches by creating the most beautiful images he could imagine and by recreating his most sensuous memories, and by so doing he both revolutionized Italian poetry and demonstrated that the creation of beauty is the most effective life preserver and political statement.

The poetry’s North African references are evoked in the modes, the tuning, and in that the entire composition is built on polyrhythmic statements of dance rhythms that range in character from the dance-like to abstractions of the dance (the dancer as seen reflected on the surface of water).

— Loren Rush, program note —

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